

Learnings from kin placement data and shifting kin success metrics

Foster Insights
University of Chicago

2025



Experienced with Foster Care Data

We have spent four years helping child welfare agencies use data to drive better outcomes



Based at the University of Chicago

Our work is informed by data and research, and we have access to world-leading experts



Centered on the Child's Experience

We root our analysis in a ground truth: where the child is placed when they are in care



Focused on Real-World Outcomes

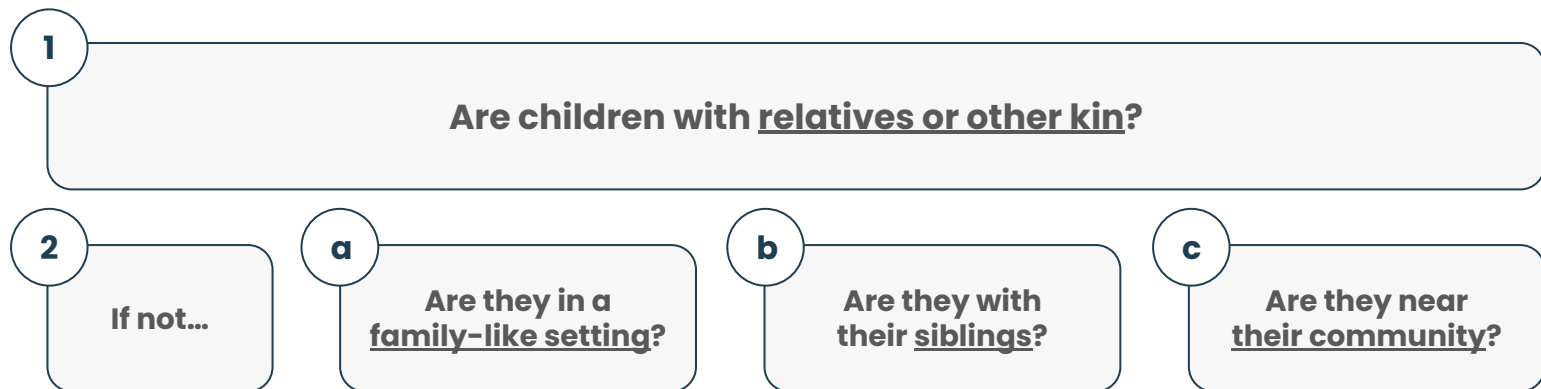
We measure success by impact, not by whether our work gets published in an academic journal



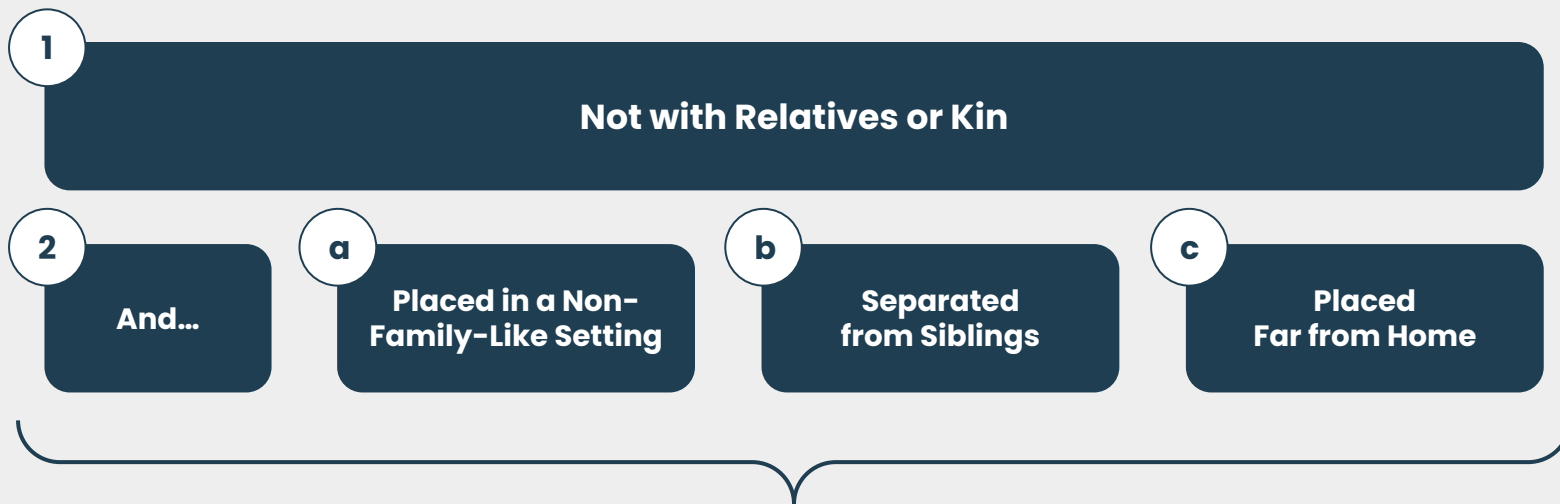
Who we are:

Foster Insights is a nonprofit dedicated to using data to improve child welfare

Using state administrative data, we ask very simple questions



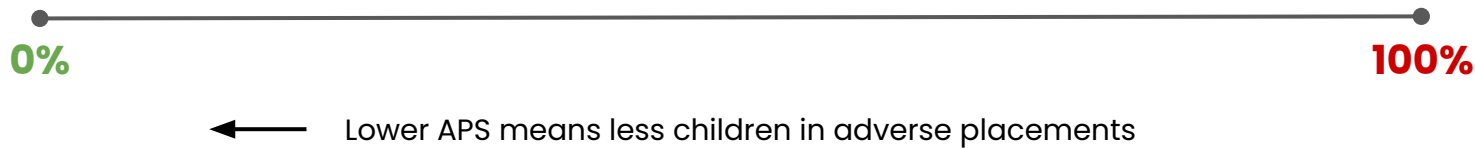
And create a simple metric to target support where gaps exist



Adverse Placement Score (APS) tracks the percent of children who were not with kin or family and were instead in at least one of the above adverse placements.

The goal of lowering APS aligns strategy with desired outcomes

APS = % of children in adverse placements



APS can be reduced by increasing placement with kin or **placement in foster homes with siblings, close to home**

As we dive deeper into this work, we uncover more benefits of kin



Stability

- Much **less likely to disrupt** compared to foster homes
- Better for child *and* worker



Connection

- Often (but not always) **closer** to child's community of origin
- More likely to take **all siblings**



Capacity

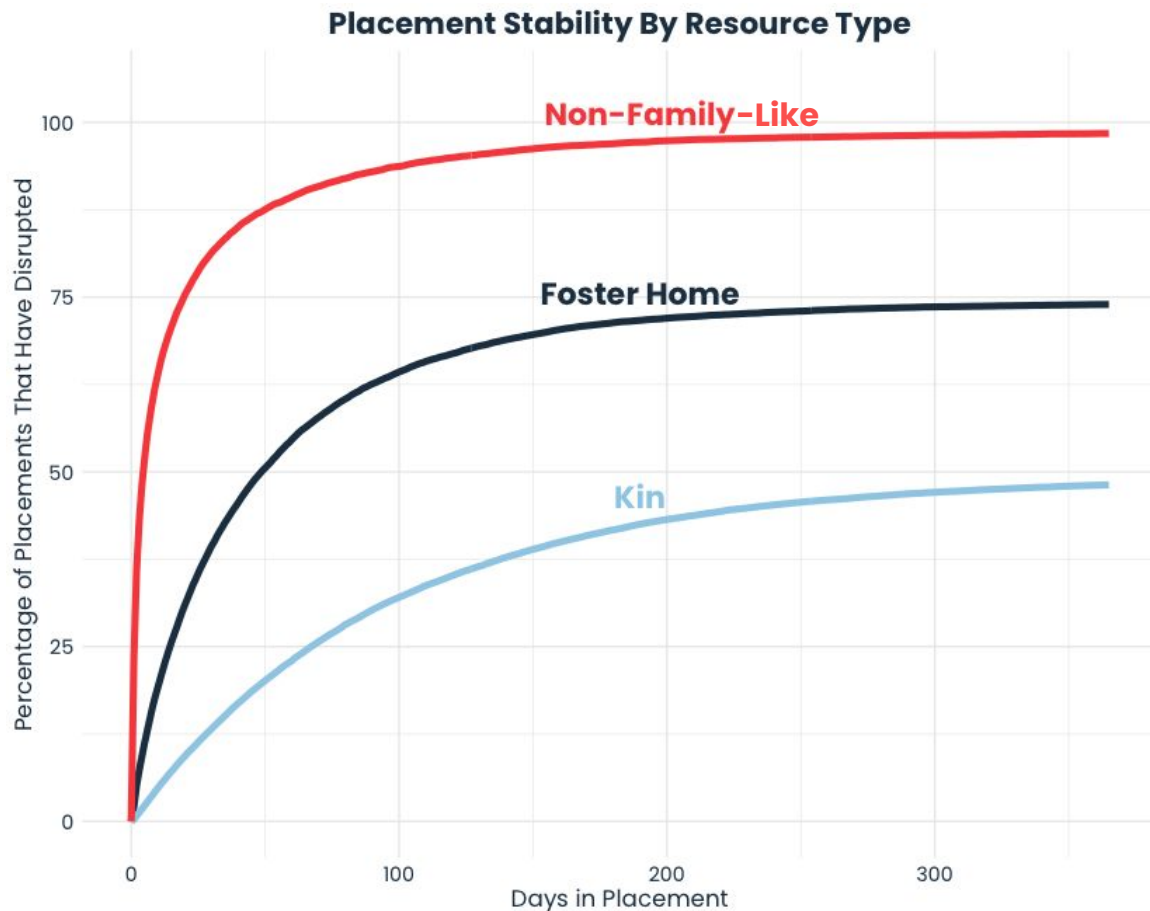
- Every kin placement **saves a foster home** for children with fewer kin connections

Leave reflections in the chat...

**What questions do you have
about kin placement that
might be answered with data?**

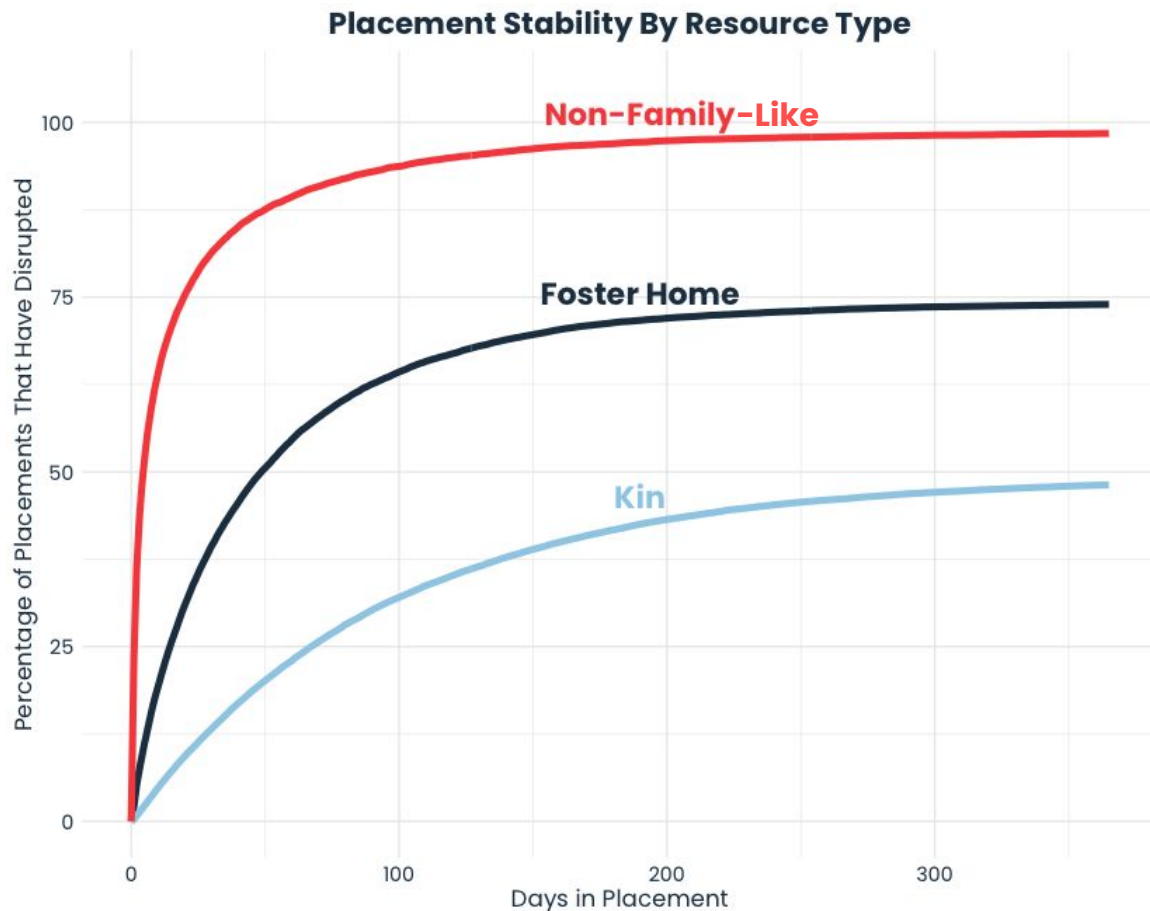
Kin placements are more stable

In **every state** that we've worked with, **kin placements are less likely to disrupt** than other settings



* Non-Family-Like placements include institutional settings (group homes, crisis centers, detention, hospital) and AWOL

Kin placements not only reduce disruption for children but also **reduce workload for placement teams**



* Non-Family-Like placements include institutional settings (group homes, crisis centers, detention, hospital) and AWOL

Kin placements support connection

Larger sibling groups tend to be placed with kin most frequently

Sibling Group Size	% Days Spent with Kin
No Siblings	50%
2 Siblings	53%
3 Siblings	55%
4 Siblings	70%
5+ Siblings	65%

Is kin-finding more challenging for individual children?

Sibling Group Size	% Days Spent with Kin
No Siblings	50%
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4 Siblings	70%
5+ Siblings	65%

Children placed with kin tend to be closer to their removal address

Placement Type	Median Drive Time To Removal Address
Kin	25 Min
Foster Home	40 Min
Non-Family-Like	110 Min

* Non-Family-Like placements include institutional settings (group homes, crisis centers, detention, hospital) and AWOL

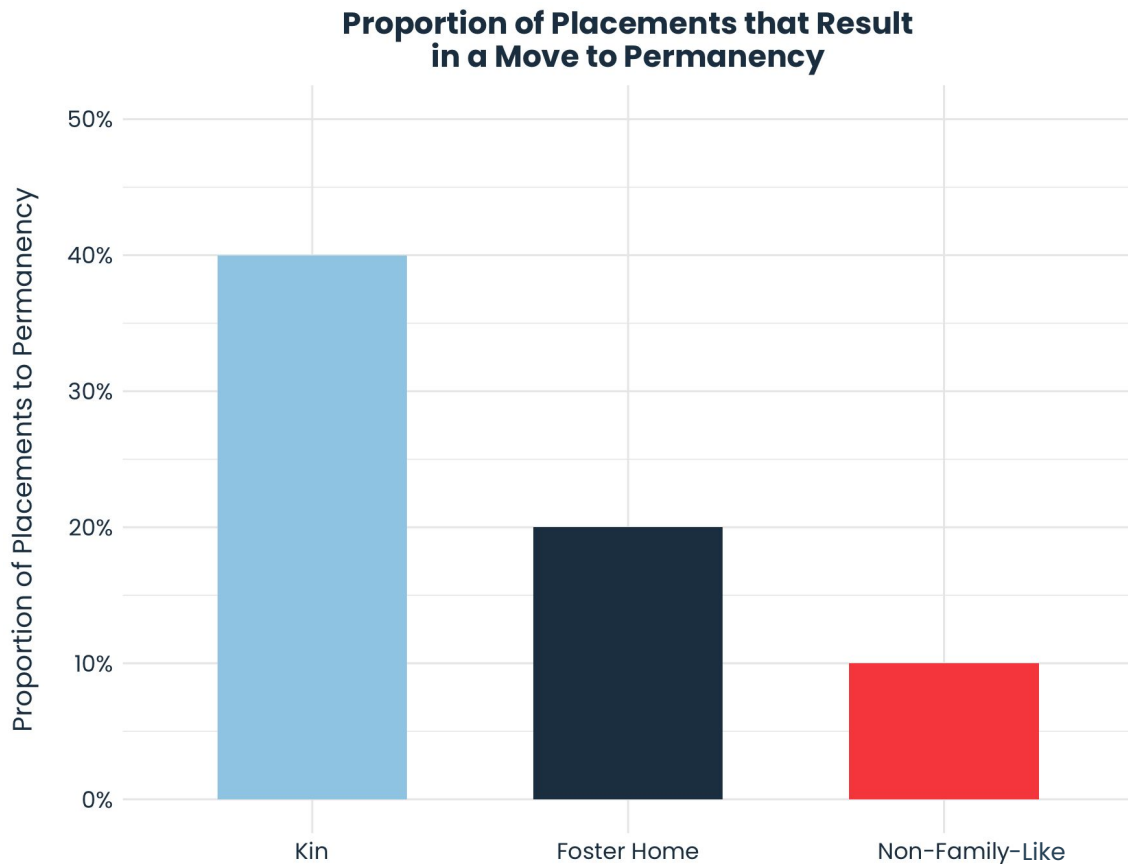
More localized kin placements benefit children and workforce

Placement Type	Median Drive Time To Removal Address
Kin	25 Min
Foster Home	40 Min
Non-Family-Like	110 Min

Closer-to-home placements enable more children to remain in their school and connected to their community

Closer-to-home placements reduce load on caseworkers by minimizing driving times

Kin placements are **significantly more likely to result in a move to permanency***



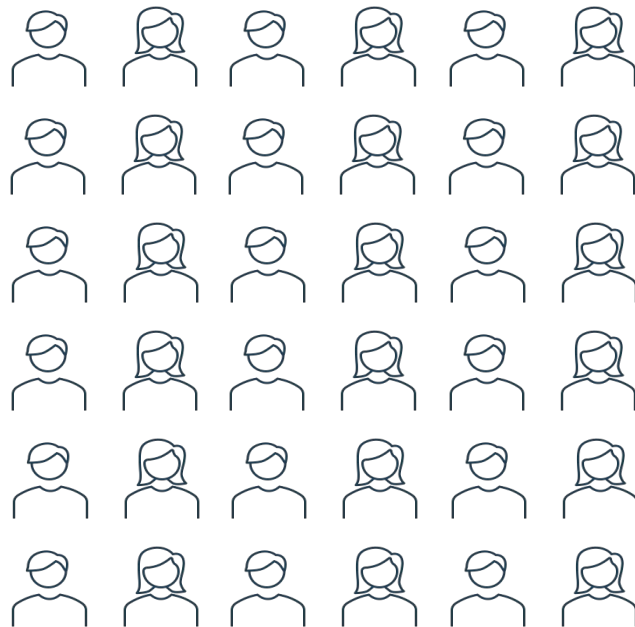
*Includes exiting care or moving to trial reunification

Kin placements increase capacity

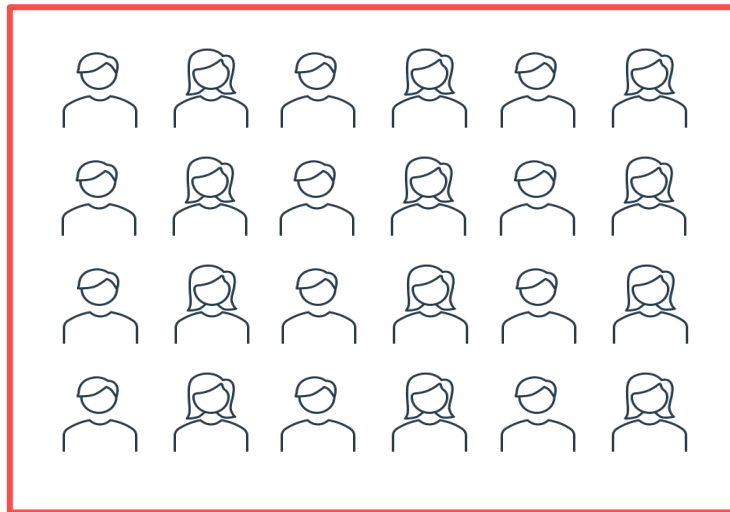


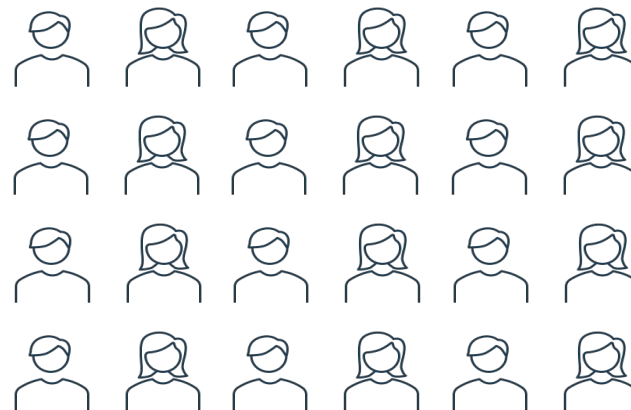
We will use Cook County, Illinois to illustrate a trend that we see in big cities across the country

In large cities, we typically see many more children than non-kin homes

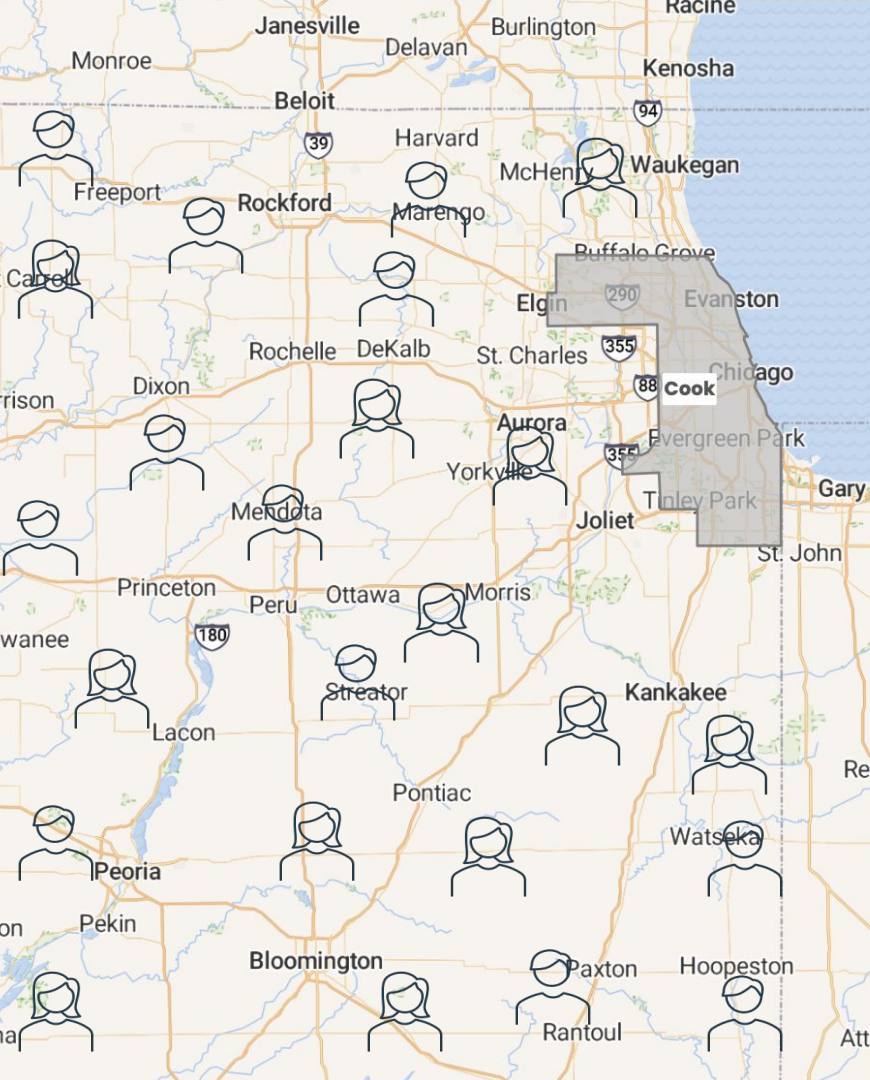


Even with perfect utilization, there are many children without a home



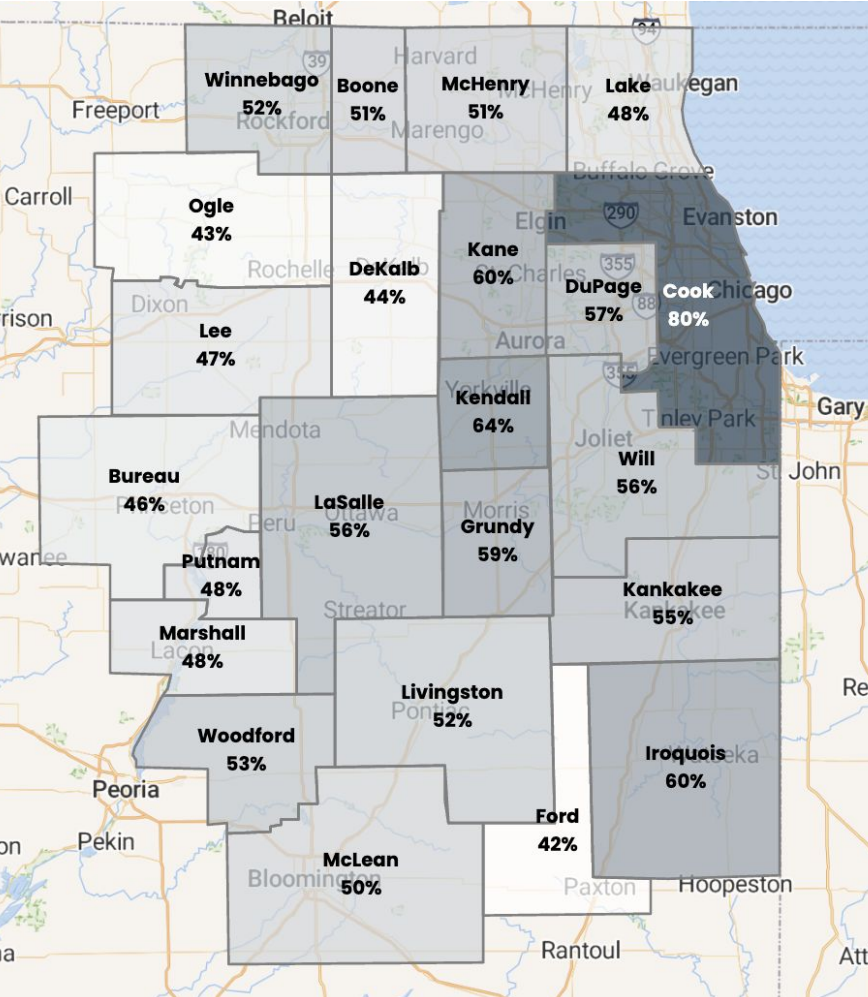


ILLUSTRATIVE DATA



Without kin placements, the foster home shortage in big cities places **huge pressure on capacity in surrounding areas**, which results in even more far away placements

% of Days with Kin by Removal County

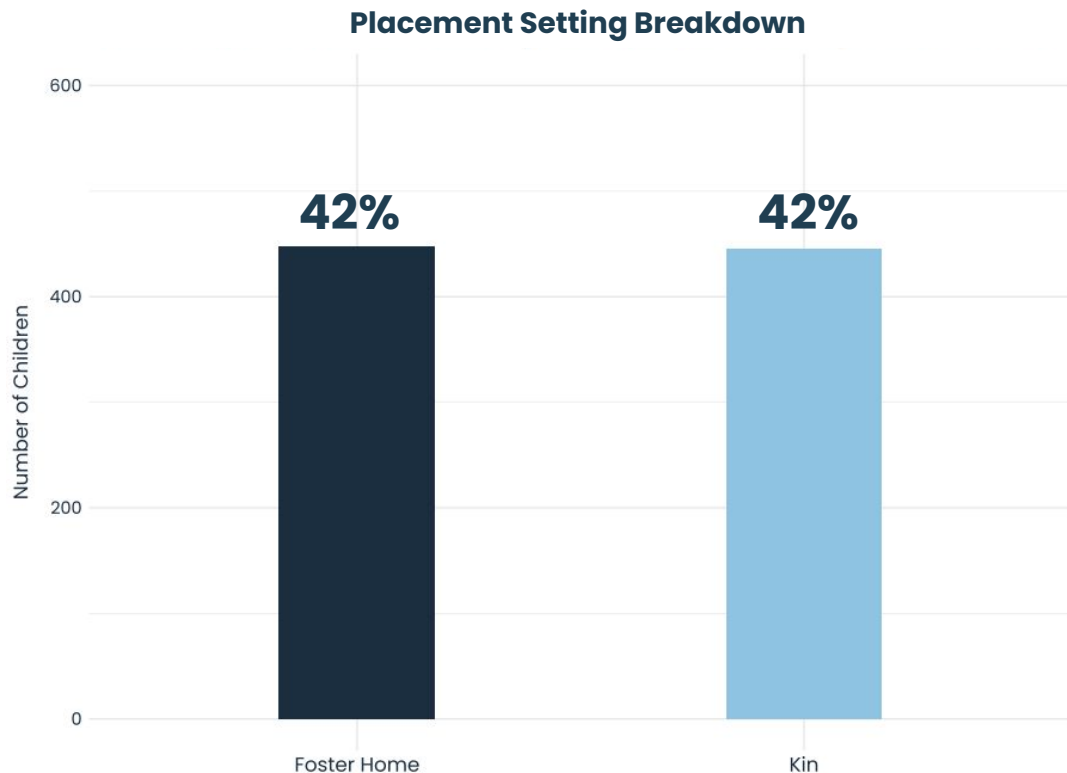


High rates of kin placement in large urban areas is an effective way to **mitigate the impact of foster home shortages**

ILLUSTRATIVE DATA

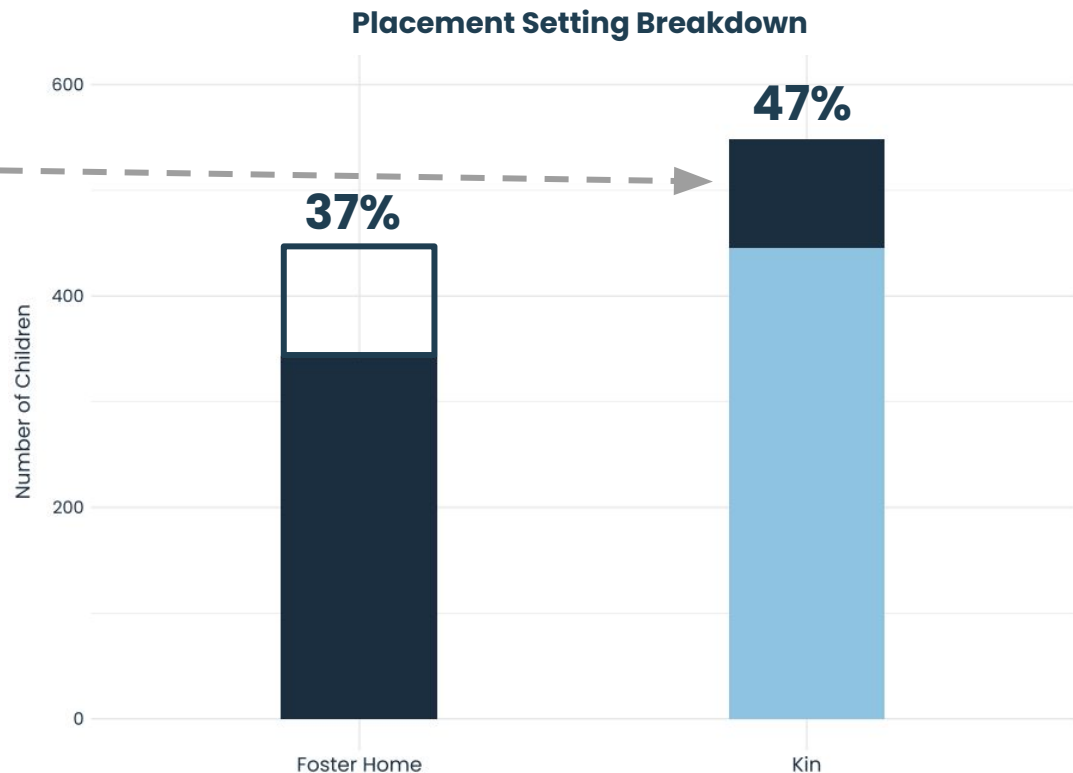
Even a small increase in kin placement can have lasting impact...

In this example county, there are roughly an equal number of children placed with kin and traditional foster homes



Even a small increase in kin placement can have lasting impact...

By increasing kin placements by 5%, not only are **more children placed with kin...**

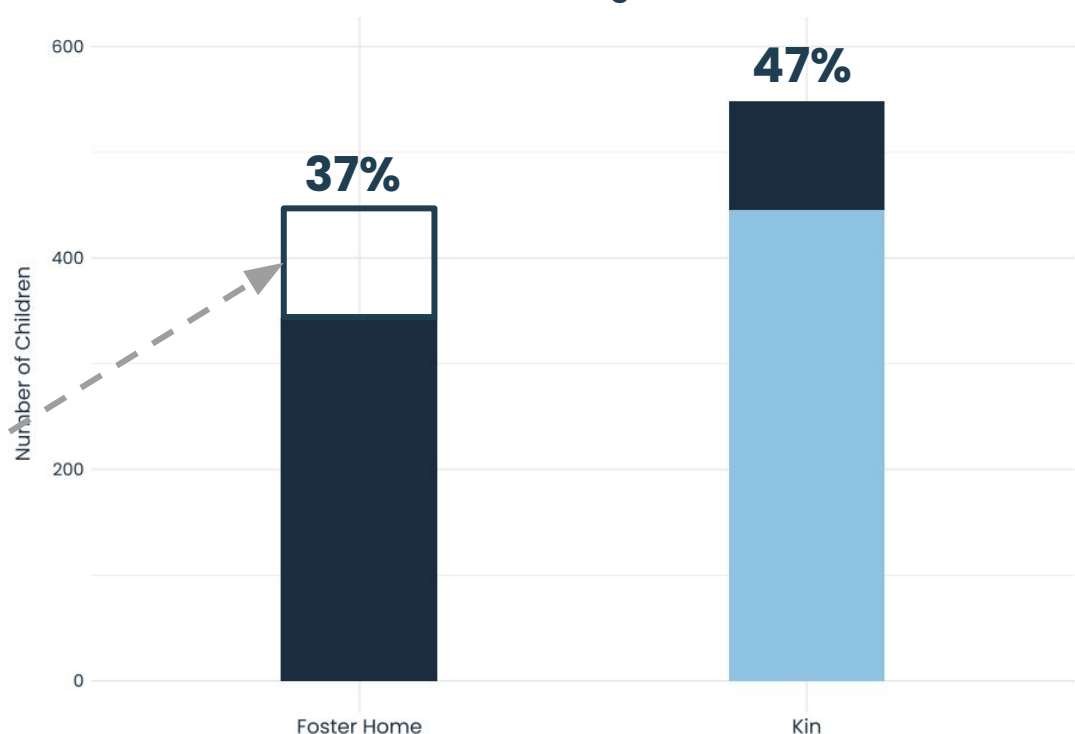


Even a small increase in kin placement can have lasting impact...

By increasing kin placements by 5%, not only are **more children placed with kin...**

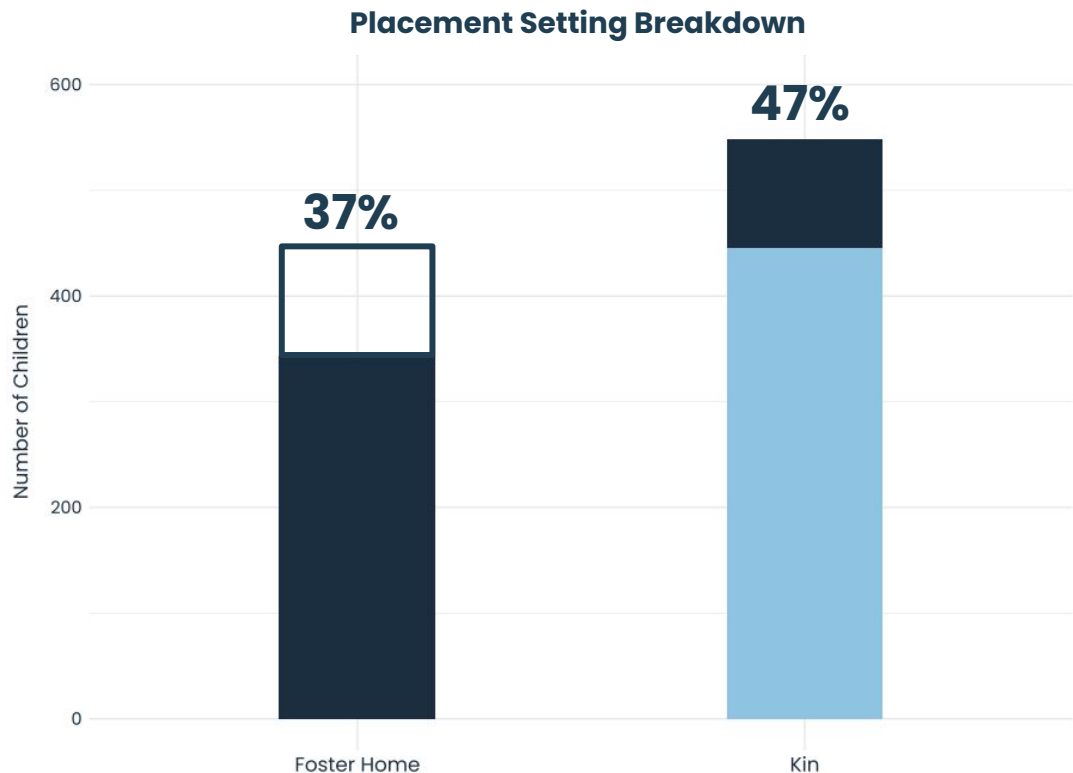
...but **dozens of traditional foster homes are also “freed up”** as children are placed with kin instead

Placement Setting Breakdown



Even a small increase in kin placement can have lasting impact...

In large cities, such an increase can mean hundreds of additional children placed with kin *and* hundreds of foster home beds available to meet the needs of other children



Looking at the data has reinforced the benefits of kin placement

- **For the child:**
 - Significantly greater stability in care
 - Likely to be placed closer to home
 - More likely to exit care or move to trial reunification after kin placement
- **For child welfare systems:**
 - Reduces workload for placement team and drive time for caseworkers
 - Frees up foster homes for children without kinship options, particularly in areas with foster home shortages

Leave reflections in the chat...

Does our data align with your experience?

Is any of this surprising? Reaffirming?

“First placement with kin” is a start

**Children in out-of-home care should
spend as much time as possible with kin**

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



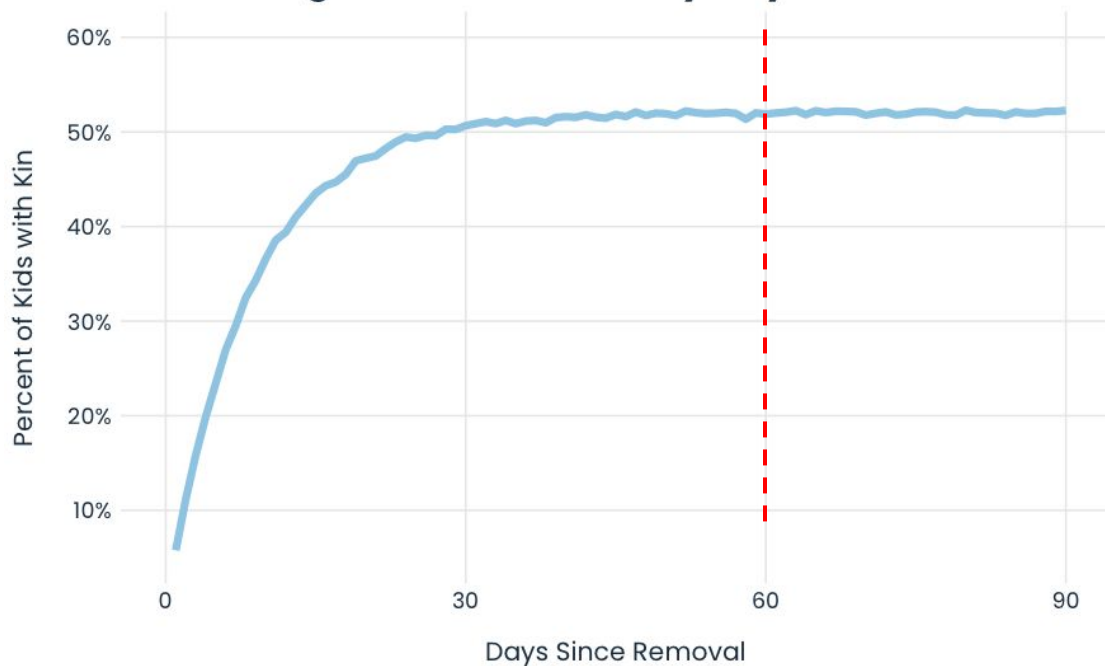
We have observed a **consistent pattern** in kin placement on each day after removal

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



The share of children with kin increases rapidly over the first month...

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



...before plateauing as the percentage of children with kin stabilizes after the first month in care

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



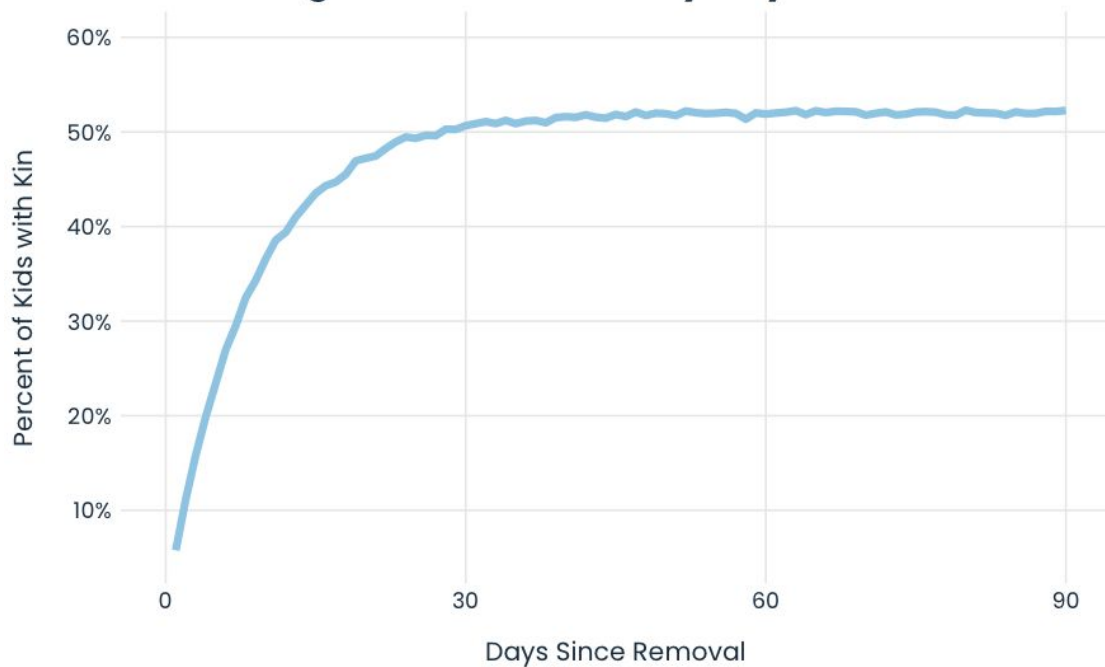
Despite the flat line,
**new kin placements
are happening after
day 30...**

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



...but they are happening at roughly the same rate as **children are leaving kin** due to placement disruptions

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



By relying solely on “first placements with kin” as our kin metric, we may...

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



By relying solely on “first placements with kin” as our kin metric, we may...

...not account for those that are placed with kin but not immediately

Percentage of Kids with Kin By Days Since Removal



By relying solely on “first placements with kin” as our kin metric, we may...

...not account for those that *are* placed with kin but not immediately

...not account for those that *are* placed with kin immediately but move out of kin soon after

“Percent of days with kin” tracks kin placement at *all* stages

- 1 Identifying the **BEST first kin placement** so that first placement sticks
- 2 Incentivizing **continuous kin-engagement** so that future placements are with kin
- 3 Providing **stability support to all kin placements** after placement is made

Leave reflections in the chat...

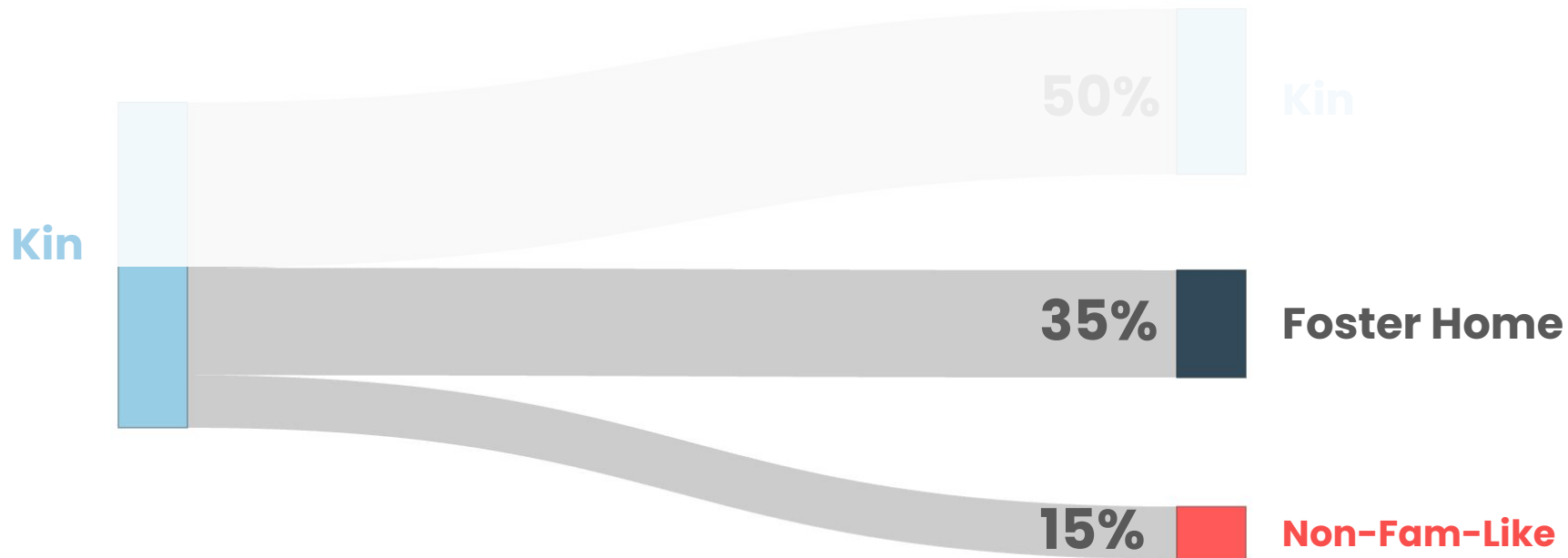
What are challenges with ongoing kin-finding?

To what extent does kin-finding happen when a child is *already placed with kin*?

**When a kin placement disrupts, children
tend to move to another kin around half the time**



The other half of disruptions result in a move to other placement settings

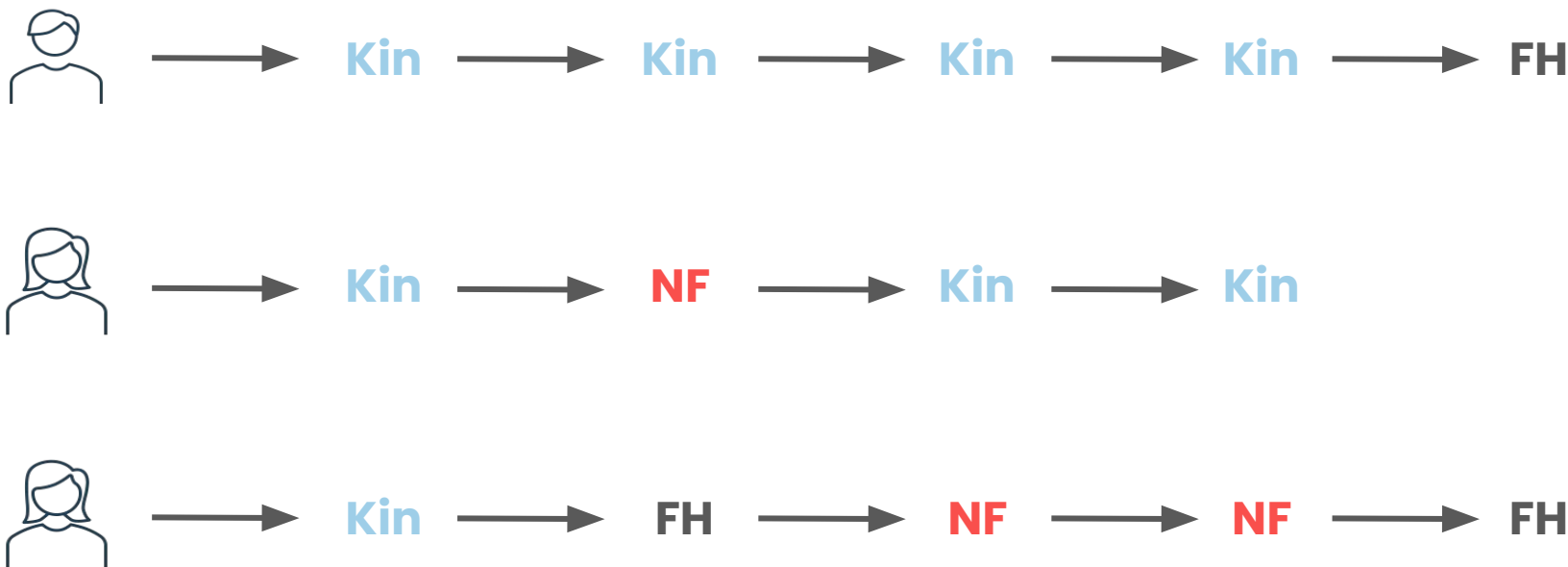


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What is the pathway through care for those children that move from a kin to a non-kin placement?

Did they have many kin placements before moving to a non-kin setting? Do they ever make it back to kin?

Moving out of kin is very different depending on the pathway through care

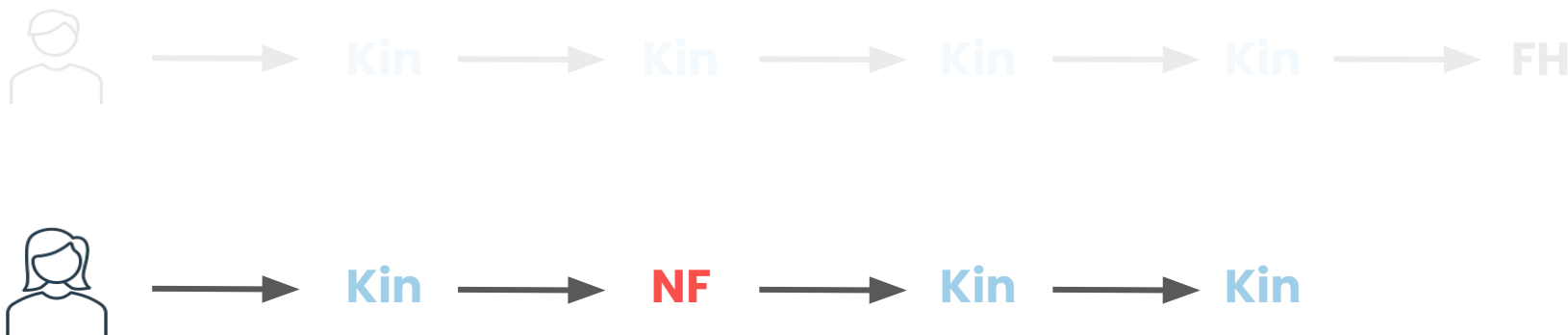


ILLUSTRATIVE DATA

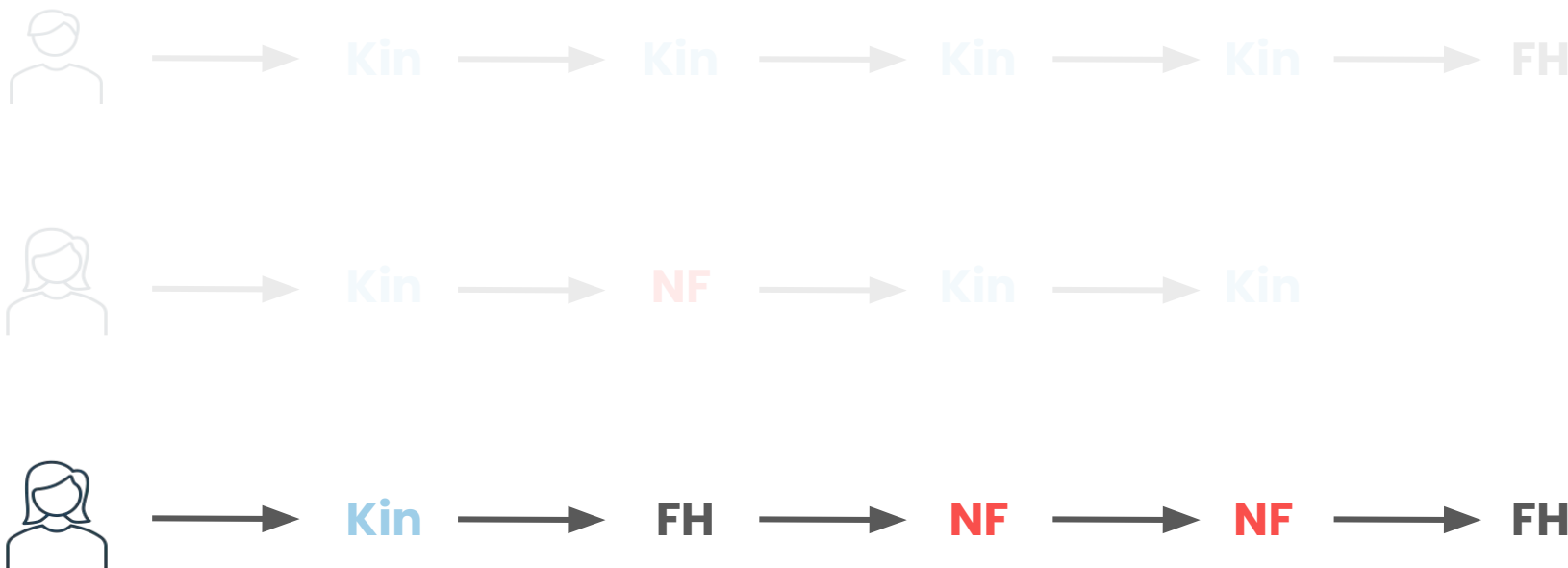
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Moving out of kin is very different depending on the pathway through care



Moving out of kin is very different depending on the pathway through care



ILLUSTRATIVE DATA

To better understand ongoing kin-finding, we break down the number of kin placements before and after moving out of kin

Kin Placements After Leaving Kin						
		0	1	2	3	4+
Kin Placements Before Leaving Kin	1					
	2					
	3					
	4+					

We have found that the most common scenario is that a child has just one kin placement and will not have another

Kin Placements After Leaving Kin						
Kin Placements Before Leaving Kin		0	1	2	3	4+
	1	45%	21%	7%	1%	1%
	2	9%	3%	3%	1%	0%
	3	2%	2%	1%	0%	0%
	4+	2%	1%	1%	0%	0%

We have found that the most common scenario is that a child has just one kin placement and will not have another

Kin Placements After Leaving Kin						
Kin Placements Before Leaving Kin		0	1	2	3	4+
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	2	9%	3%	3%	1%	0%
	3	2%	2%	1%	0%	0%
	4+	2%	1%	1%	0%	0%

Additional kin-finding, both at entry into care and on an ongoing basis, may help keep children with kin even when a placement disrupts

Leave reflections in the chat...

What other data-specific questions do you have?

What are the limitations of your data right now?

Thank you!

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